warmth, and so on and so on and so on. And just as I thought I had made my point and nailed it down, she suddenly said, wryly, "But your wife is beautiful. Right?"

I said, "Right," and the argument was ruined.

The high point came on the evening of July 15, after dinner, when I suggested a walk to the highway where there was some sort of icecream parlor. I offered to stand any young woman willing to accompany me sundaes, sodas, or whatever they wanted, and with no limit to the numbers. Five of them came along.

They were all in their early twenties, all single, all reasonably pleasant in appearance. We all walked slowly, with myself between two girls with an arm about the waist of each—and changing girls periodically, so that none would feel neglected. It seemed to me that I was at my best, my most amusing and charming, and the sound of soprano laughter frightened the birds for miles around.

We reached the ice-cream parlor finally and I said, "All right, girls, anything you want."

The man behind the counter looked at them and then at me (who was, after all, fat and quite ordinary-looking) and said, "All these girls with you?"

"That's right," I said.

He said, "Can you take care of all of them?"

And I said loftily, "Do any of them look unhappy?"

And indeed, they didn't. I loved the look of awe and respect that shone in his eyes.

We finally got home on July 19 and the two Blugermans went on

to New York. Gertrude had managed the city heat in our absence by sleeping on the porch nights. It was the equivalent of an air-conditioned room, and, since the landlord had now put screens around it, it was mosquito-free as well.

David had gotten through the week with no trouble also. In my absence he was weaned—or he weaned himself. In any case, he now rejected the bottle and preferred to slobber messily with a glass.